

Beaver County Times

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Bridge's life spans 100 years

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Times photo by LUCY SCHALY

This picture, taken from Antoline Park in Monaca, shows the P&LE Railroad Bridge over the Ohio River between Monaca and Beaver. This year marks the 100th anniversary of the opening of the bridge.

BEAVER — The Pittsburgh and Lake Erie Railroad bridge across the Ohio River is like an old friend for longtime Beaver resident Bob Smith.

Smith, 83, figures he crossed the bridge between Monaca and Beaver at least 15,000 times while commuting by train to Pittsburgh before he retired.

"I crossed that bridge probably 600 times a year for 26 years," Smith said. "I still have my punch card from my last trip."

Next month the landmark bridge turns 100 years old. Now owned by Jacksonville, Fla.-based CSX Corp, it still serves numerous trains daily without a glitch.

The bridge was proclaimed an engineering marvel when it opened in 1910, and its hulking steel mass remains an emblem of Beaver County's former industrial might.

Standing at the mouth of the Beaver River, it serves as a gateway to the Beaver Valley, and one P&LE researcher believes it was directly responsible for transforming the county into one of the nation's largest industrial centers during the last century.

Jack Polaritz, 66, of New Kent, Va., whose fourth book on the P&LE, "Engine for Change," is scheduled for release this fall, said the bridge was critical in Beaver County's rise to industrial prominence.

The P&LE was the main railroad serving mills across the county, he said. An existing bridge wasn't large enough to handle rapidly increasing traffic from plants such as J&L Steel Co.'s Aliquippa Works.

"It was the P&LE Railroad that really built Beaver County," said Polaritz, a former resident of Findlay Township. "There was nobody else but the P&LE to service these mills, and that bridge was the only way to get across the river. It was, at its time, the largest cantilever bridge in the world."

Work began in 1908, and the bridge officially opened on May 14, 1910.

The bridge was built by local labor with steel fabricated in Rankin and stone quarried in Beaver Valley. It features four unique arched concrete tunnels under the earthen approach on the Beaver side that were built to allow Pennsylvania Railroad trains to pass underneath and as a drain for flood waters.

The total cost was estimated at \$2 million, an amount equal to \$50 million in 2010.

It also cost one worker his life.

On April 21, 1910, E.B. Gullion of Bridgewater slipped off the deck, struck one of the stone piers and plunged 90 feet into the river, the Daily Times of Beaver reported in that day's edition. Gullion, who suffered a broken neck and fractured skull, died the following day in Rochester Hospital.

The bridge was completed less than a month later. Contractors turned it over to the railroad on May 10, 1910, according to the Daily Times. The railroad tested the bridge that same day by running a train pulling 20 freight cars loaded with iron ore across the structure. The train's total weight was estimated at 5.8 million pounds.

A crowd of company officials and engineers assembled to witness the event.

"Without so much as a quiver the bridge withstood its massive load, proving beyond doubt that it was substantial," the Daily Times reported. "Then the crowd cheered."

Four days later the railroad christened the bridge.

Hundreds turned out for the christening, including James M. Schoonmaker, who headed the railroad, and other dignitaries. Schoonmaker's daughter, Greeta, christened it by breaking a champagne bottle on the structure.

The Daily Times reported that her eyes "fairly sparkled with delight during the proceedings." Her father was so happy, the paper said, that it was difficult for him to "give utterance to his feelings."

"Yes this is the first time I ever saw a bridge opened for traffic," Greeta Schoonmaker told the Daily Times. "It is all so fine."

The Buffalo Limited was the first passenger train to cross the bridge. It was operated by J.L. Whitla of Beaver Falls, who also drove the first train across the P&LE's first bridge across the Ohio between Monaca and Beaver.

Schoonmaker, who arrived in a private train car draped with orange and black bunting, stood with his wife and daughter, waving American flags as the Buffalo Limited passed.

Polaritz said at least 100 trains passed over the bridge every day during the height of the P&LE's operations.

Over the years, the bridge has served as a local attraction for photographers, train watchers and students of 20th-century engineering feats. It also attracted youngsters from the Beaver Valley.

Charles Townsend, a retired Beaver Area High School English teacher, said high school kids would jump off the bridge 90 feet to the river below as a rite of passage during summer months.

"They'd go down there and jump off one of the piers," he said. "That was mainly in the 1970s. I don't hear about that anymore."

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The P&LE stopped running passenger trains in 1985. Bob Smith, then retired, said he couldn't pass up the chance to pass over an old friend one last time. He took that last ride on July 12, 1985.

“I drove into Pittsburgh just so I could ride the train home on the last run,” he said. “I still have my ticket from that day.”